avails services such as banking, transport, insurance, etc., is also called a consumer. In other words, a consumer is an individual who consumes goods- manufactured by firms or created by nature air, water etc.and services offered by government or firms, hospitals, educational institutions etc.,

Meaning of Consumer under The Indian Consumer Protection Act, 1986

A person who buys any goods or services for a consideration which has been paid or promised or partly paid and partly promised or under any system of deferred payment is a consumer.

A person who obtains such goods for resale or for any commercial purposes will not be a consumer. However, if such goods are bought by a person exclusively for the purpose of earning his livelihood by means of self-employment then such a person will be considered a consumer.

In theory, all business enterprises consider consumer's satisfaction as their main objective. A consumer is said to be the king and the businessmen are primarily supposed to serve and satisfy customers. The consumer occupies the central position in the entire scheme of free economy; consumers have not always received the attention they deserve. In reality consumers are cheated and exploited in many ways. In the practical world, a consumer is a 'slave' and not the 'sovereign' as described.

The consumer's well-being or the welfare lies in the fulfilment of their normal, legitimate, interests, expectations and aspirations as to goods and services they need. Each and every customer is worried, and harmed till buried about the quality, quantity, price and the timeliness of the supply of goods and services they need.

16.02 Consumer Exploitation

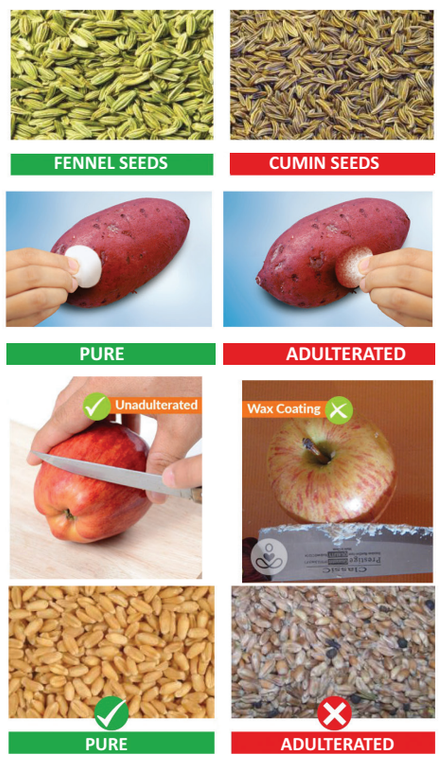
Some of the ways in which consumers are being exploited are enumerated hereunder:

1. Selling at Higher Price

The price charged by the seller for a product service may not be commensurate with the quality but at times it is more than the fair price. Even though sellers have surplus or adequate goods they create artificial scarcity in the market with an intent to push up the prices. As a result, consumers are forced to buy the short supply of goods at higher prices in the black market.

2. Adulteration

It refers to mixing or substituting undesirable material in food. This causes heavy loss to the consumers. This will lead to monitory loss and spoil the health. But adulterators make illegitimate profit while prudent businessmen aim at normal profit whenever unscrupulous traders seek to reap higher profit out of greed, they seek to adulterate the products. Adulteration is quite common in food articles. It is a crime which cannot be pardoned as it spoils the very health of consumers.



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